FUGUE III

In this Fugue the Subject, as exposed in a brilliant Stretto with Inversion in the third voice, is a bar and a half long; and wherever (as later in bars 14-17) the whole of it is to be found, the whole must be emphasised. On the other hand, in by far the greater bulk of the Fugue nothing more of the Subject is heard than its first four notes and, as great sport is made with these and their Augmentations, Diminutions and Inversions, no distinction is to be drawn between complete and incomplete entries of the Subject. These first four notes should always be detached (even in diminution) and always given with point; the inverted figure requiring just as much emphasis when, as often happens, its first interval is reduced to a tone or semitone, or (more capriciously) widened to a fifth or fourth as in bars 12, 27 (middle voice). The Augmentation in bars 25-26 and 27-28 is a matter of moment, to be trumpeted forth by way of leading to the climax on the dominant pedal.

In the British Museum autograph we catch Bach in the act of adding detail of a kind which involves slackening the *tempo* in order to make room for it. Originally, most of the semiquaver passages were unbroken, but in bars 28-29 Bach (who is evidently copying an older sketch) begins to put in the characteristic pairs of demisemiquavers which in the best copies of his pupils pervade the composition from the appearance of the new figure in bar 8 onwards. That new figure, with its Inversion, has all the importance of a new theme, and provides a contrasting *legato* element when the rest of the Subject is lost sight of. There is no doubt that the best copies have faithfully represented Bach's final decisions, all the more since they do not show the tell-tale uniformity of the theorist who would infallibly have carried the demisemiquavers of bars 15-16 back into the Exposition itself (bars 2-3). Bach amuses himself royally with the *disjecta membra* of his Subject, but for that very reason he refuses to be bored with uniformities, and, since writing the British Museum autograph, he even filled up the first interval of the Subject itself with an intervening semiquaver in bar 28.

The Fugue is not difficult to interpret and enjoy on the basis of these facts, with the semiquaver and demisemiquaver themes (other than the diminished subject figure) to provide the *cantabile* element, and the *tempo* a humorously pompous swinging eight in the bar, requiring some broadening from bar 32 to the end.

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